

"WITH DIGITAL MEDIA ASKING THEM NO QUESTIONS, ONLY GIVING ANSWERS, CHILDREN THESE DAYS DON'T FEEL THE NEED TO SPEAK OR COMMUNICATE OFFLINE"

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objects at us. He would bottle up all his frustrations inside and let them all out in the games. Sometimes that violence would turn towards us too."

Ishan's current therapy at the AIIMS clinic focuses on behavioural tricks that allow him to speak his mind rather than suppress his emotions. For instance, when he is not allowed to speak to friends on the phone at night, his therapist now encourages him to communicate his anger and frustration instead of expending it in violent digital games. The Saxenas now observe a 'device-free' lunch on Sunday, when all four family members sit together at the dining table and eat, giving their two children a chance to engage in and appreciate an offline conversation.

Dr Sharma, who has helped many patients overcome their digital addiction, says such 'digital fasts' are a very effective first step toward going offline. He advises one to "start small", say, a few hours every week when one mandatorily observes digital abstinence, and gradually increase the number of hours.

Force, most therapists agree, is the worst way to tackle addiction. "Confiscating your child's phone or judging or nagging them does not help. It only makes them defensive and unwilling to find solutions," says Dr Patel. A young patient at the SHUT Clinic specifically asked his counsellor initially to ask his parents to find balance in the use of technology—not using the phone at all was not a viable solution. For weeks, the teenager had not been able to speak to his friends as school was closed and they lived far away. The social isolation made him all the more depressed and desperate to find ways to go online. "Phones are not bad by themselves. It is all about a healthy, balanced usage pattern," says Dr Chaddha.

In the absence of a device, many find it difficult to communicate with friends and family. When her parents enforced a 'no phones at night' policy because her eight-year-old brother was getting hooked to gaming, 17-year-old Shubha Nanda did not know what to do. Taking a gap year between school and college to figure out what to study further, night was when Shubha would speak to her friends on Whatsapp. So severe was the impact of the restriction that Shubha began to develop social anxiety and severe FOMO. Finally, she had to undergo therapy to discover JOMO or the joy of missing out. "I now realise that not speaking to friends every day is perfectly okay," she says. "Moreover, I make efforts to meet them outside, so I don't feel isolated."

FOMO, many psychologists believe, has indeed become the greatest challenge to deaddiction. Deleting various apps, keeping a journal, finding new hobbies and offline social circles, and having a support system for encouragement and motivation are some ways to drive it away. Health counselling, behaviour and mindfulness therapy are other ways to help individuals strike a balance in internet usage.